SDG BLOCKCHAIN ACCELERATOR

Mentor Feedback Report : Plastiks

Program: EMURGO : UNDP Blockchain Accelerator (Cohort 2)
Project: Plastiks : Circular Economy Traceability Platform
Geographic Focus: Latin America, India, Global
Mentorship Focus: Platform Integration Strategy, Ecosystem Interoperability, Operational Expansion
Total Mentoring Sessions: 4
Mentor: Yoram Ben Zvi, Ahmed M.Amer

1. Initial Context and Project Status

Plastiks entered Cohort 2 in a very different position compared to most teams in the accelerator. While many projects were building early prototypes, Plastiks already had a functioning platform and had previously participated in Cohort 1.

The project focuses on improving transparency in plastic recovery and recycling processes by linking real-world waste collection and recycling activities with digital records that can be verified and potentially tied to environmental impact metrics.

By the time mentoring began in Cohort 2, Plastiks had already achieved several milestones:

- Development of an operational platform for plastic recovery traceability
- Integration of carbon and environmental impact methodologies
- Engagement with waste collection networks
- Early exploration of tokenization models tied to recycling impact

Because of this level of maturity, mentoring did not focus heavily on foundational architecture or smart contract design. Instead, discussions centered around **how the platform could evolve**, integrate with other accelerator solutions, and support additional actors in the circular economy.

2. Mentoring Focus: Platform Expansion Rather Than Platform Creation

One of the most important distinctions in the mentoring process for Plastiks was recognizing that the team was not building a new system but **extending an existing one**.

The primary mentoring objective therefore became identifying areas where the platform could expand its operational reach without introducing unnecessary complexity.

Two questions guided most mentoring discussions:

1. Which additional actors in the recycling ecosystem are currently excluded from the platform?
2. What infrastructure is required to include them without disrupting existing workflows?

Through this lens, it became clear that a significant portion of the plastic recovery ecosystem operates outside of digital systems altogether.

In many regions, waste collection is performed by individuals or informal groups who:

- do not use smartphones,
- do not have reliable internet access,
- and often interact with recycling supply chains through intermediaries.

3. Cross-Team Integration Opportunity

During the accelerator, a natural connection emerged between Plastiks and another project in the cohort: xCapit.

While Plastiks focused on circular economy traceability, xCapit had developed a Low-Tech Wallet (LTW) infrastructure designed specifically for feature-phone environments using SMS and USSD.

Mentoring discussions identified a clear synergy between the two systems.

If Plastiks could integrate with xCapit's LTW infrastructure, it would become possible to include a new category of participants in the Plastiks ecosystem: informal trash collectors who operate without smartphones.

This integration would allow these collectors to:

- receive payments through USSD-based wallet interactions,
- participate in traceability systems indirectly,
- and become visible actors in the circular economy supply chain.

This represented one of the most interesting outcomes of Cohort 2 because it demonstrated the value of cross-team architecture alignment within the accelerator.

4. Mentoring Sessions and Key Discussions

Session 1 : Platform Architecture Review

The first mentoring session focused on understanding Plastiks' existing platform architecture and identifying where integration points might exist.

Unlike many other teams, Plastiks did not rely directly on EMURGO's scaffolds or reference repositories. The platform had already developed its own infrastructure during earlier phases.

The discussion therefore focused on compatibility rather than adoption.

Key questions included:

- Where in the Plastiks workflow do payments occur?
- How are collectors currently identified in the system?
- What assumptions does the platform make about user devices?

One observation that emerged early was that many platform flows implicitly assumed smartphone usage. While this may be realistic in some markets, it excludes a large portion of informal waste collectors.

This observation later shaped the integration direction.

Session 2 : Inclusion of Informal Collectors

The second session focused on the operational role of informal collectors.

These individuals often represent the **first link in the recycling supply chain**, yet they are also the least digitally represented. In many systems they are either invisible or recorded indirectly through aggregators.

Mentoring discussions emphasized that including these actors directly; even if through very simple interfaces; could significantly strengthen the credibility and impact of the Plastiks platform.

However, doing so required solving two problems:

1. **Identity** : how collectors are identified in the system
2. **Payments** : how collectors receive compensation

At this stage, the connection with xCapit's LTW infrastructure became more concrete.

Rather than attempting to build a new low-connectivity payment system from scratch, Plastiks could leverage an existing solution developed within the accelerator.

Session 3 : Integration Strategy with xCapit

The third mentoring session explored how such an integration could realistically occur.

Rather than attempting deep technical coupling between the two platforms, the mentor recommended a modular integration approach.

In this model:

- Plastiks continues to operate its existing traceability platform.
- xCapit provides wallet infrastructure for collectors.
- Payments and interactions between the two systems occur through defined interfaces.

This approach has several advantages:

- Each system remains independently maintainable.
- Integration risk is reduced.
- Both projects benefit from ecosystem collaboration.

Session 4 : Platform Positioning and Future Direction

The final session focused less on technology and more on positioning.

Plastiks already has a working platform, but the question going forward is how the platform evolves within the broader sustainability and circular economy landscape.

Mentor feedback highlighted two important strategic considerations.

First, the platform should avoid becoming overly complex by trying to incorporate too many blockchain-specific features. The real value of the system lies in supply chain transparency and environmental impact verification.

Second, Plastiks should continue focusing on real operational partnerships, particularly with organizations and networks that manage waste collection programs.

The integration with low-tech payment infrastructure represents an important step toward making the system more inclusive and grounded in real-world operations.

5. Overall Mentor Assessment

Plastiks stands out within the cohort as one of the few teams that already had a functioning platform before entering the accelerator.

This maturity changes the nature of mentorship significantly. Rather than guiding early architecture decisions, mentoring focused on helping the team think about expansion, interoperability, and long-term positioning.

The integration discussion with xCapit was particularly valuable because it addressed a real limitation in the existing platform: the inability to include collectors who do not have access to smartphones or internet connectivity.

If implemented carefully, this integration could extend the platform's reach into segments of the recycling ecosystem that are typically excluded from digital systems.

6. Strengths Observed

Several strengths became clear during the mentoring process.

The team demonstrated strong product maturity and a clear understanding of the circular economy space. Unlike many early-stage blockchain projects, Plastiks is grounded in a real operational environment.

The platform architecture also appears sufficiently flexible to support integration with other systems without requiring major redesign.

Finally, the team showed openness to exploring collaboration with other accelerator projects rather than treating the platform as a closed system.

7. Challenges and Risks

Despite the platform's maturity, several challenges remain.

One risk is the complexity that can arise when integrating multiple systems and partners. Cross-platform integrations often introduce operational dependencies that must be carefully managed.

Another challenge is ensuring that the inclusion of new participant types; such as informal collectors; does not create additional friction in the platform's workflows.

Finally, the project will need to maintain a clear narrative around the role of blockchain in the system. The technology should support transparency and verification, but the primary value proposition remains supply chain visibility and environmental accountability.

8. Mentor Conclusion

Plastiks represents one of the more operationally grounded projects within the accelerator. The platform is already addressing a real problem and has progressed beyond the stage of purely technical experimentation.

The most valuable outcome of Cohort 2 mentoring was the identification of opportunities for ecosystem collaboration, particularly the integration with xCapit's low-connectivity wallet infrastructure.

If pursued carefully, this collaboration could significantly expand the inclusiveness and reach of the Plastiks platform by enabling participation from actors who were previously excluded from digital traceability systems.

Going forward, the project's success will depend less on adding new technical features and more on continuing to deepen its integration with real recycling supply chains and sustainability programs.